

ly shielded, so having them closer to your monitor can cause distortions in both sound *and* picture. If you own a 5.1 surround sound speaker system, keep in mind that audio from the centre speaker *fans out* horizontally, so the best place for it is above your monitor, where the sound won't encounter any obstacles.

Tip

To get the most out of your subwoofer, place it in a corner. The sound will reflect off the three wall surfaces, sending a very desirable blast all across your room.

Finally, check the speakers themselves—plug them into your music system as well, and check if they work fine. If they do, then the problem goes deeper than just speakers.

Sound Card Woes

Have you installed the latest drivers for your card? Every time you install drivers, make sure that you follow the installation instructions to the letter—there are no shortcuts to good sound.

Electro-magnetic interference is possible within your cabinet, too. Make sure that the sound card is not too close to other cards.

Have you connected any hardware you don't use? Every device reserves some resources for itself, so make sure you remove any devices you don't use.

If you don't have a microphone or a device connected to your Line-in jack, make sure that both the Microphone and Line-in are muted—any unused input is a potential noisemaker. To do this, double-click on the Volume icon in the System tray and check Mute for both. If you don't see a volume slider for either, go to Options > Properties and in the dialog, check the mute boxes for Microphone and Line-in.

System Woes

Sometimes sound won't play properly for the simple reason that your CPU is too slow to handle it! You should first try optimising your sys-